

LITERATURE AND CULTURE

READING AND WRITING WOMEN IN THE VICTORIAN AGE

LEAD IN

1 Look at this stereograph, representing a 'new woman' in the Victorian Age. Then answer the following questions.

1. What is the woman doing?
2. What is the man doing in the other room?
3. What does this picture reveal about the way in which 'reading women' were perceived in the Victorian Age?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.



How did the increase in the number of female readers affect the development of Victorian novels?

Women as readers. One of the historical reasons for the success of novels in the Victorian Age is the role **women** played as **readers and consumers of fiction**. It is a historical fact that in the Victorian Age, more women, mainly of wealthy origins, were granted the opportunity to obtain a **formal education**, increasing women's presence within the Victorian reading public. Reading was also perceived as a perfectly **suitable activity** for a Victorian woman. It was considered a virtuous and acceptable pastime according to Victorian moral standards, which confined women almost exclusively to **the private sphere of their homes**. The increase in the number of female readers in the Victorian Age implied the need for novelists to consider the tastes of this 'new' type of readers: many Victorian novelists tackled **topics** that were particularly **interesting to an audience composed of women**, such as the role of women in society, the dynamics of domestic life, the relationship between free will and marriage, and the need for women's financial independence.

What role did Victorian female writers play in the history of English literature?

Women writers. In the Victorian Age, women were not only consumers of fiction; many female writers published their literary works, many of which became popular among readers and are still extremely popular today. Given the strict moral boundaries which limited women's participation in the cultural life of the age, Victorian female writers had to face many challenges and constrictions: in particular, almost all of them had to hide their female identity under **male pseudonyms** to be able to have their works published and circulated. This is what happened to the so-called **Brontë sisters**, three talented sisters who could not publish their works of fiction using their real names because that would have been unacceptable according to Victorian gender norms. Victorian female writers played a significant role in the history of English and Western literature because their works helped the reading public become aware of **women-related issues** and promoted the **development of women's rights and active participation** in a healthy society.

← 'A leisure hour' by Myles Birket Foster. Illustration from *The Girl's Own Annual*, 1893/1894.



What do the works of Charlotte and Emily Brontë explore?

The 'golden isolation' of the Brontë sisters. The Brontë sisters do not fall easily into any of the traditional classifications of Victorian literature. Emily and Charlotte were considered the most talented of the three sisters and published two of the most famous English novels of all time, respectively *Wuthering Heights* (1847) and *Jane Eyre* (1847). These two novels represented an alternative to the triumph of mainstream Victorian novels: rather than focusing on social issues, the works of the Brontë sisters explored the world of passion and feelings.

Emily Brontë's *Wuthering Heights* (→ p. 280) follows the literary tradition inaugurated by Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) (→ p. 243) and explores the **impossible love** between Heathcliff, a Byronic hero, and Catherine, a woman torn between passion and social conventions. The novel also explores the **condition of life of women** and their lack of independence in a world dominated by men as well as the contrast between individual aspirations and the limitations imposed by life.

Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre* (→ p. 288) revolves around a strong and passionate female character, Jane, who falls in love with a mysterious man called Rochester. Charlotte's novel contains a subtle exploration of the theme of **womanhood** and opens a window on the **dark sides of human personality** through the analysis of Jane's alter-ego Bertha Mason, Rochester's secret (and supposedly crazy) wife.

Having spent much of their lives in a remote village in Yorkshire, with little to no connections to the literary panorama of the age, the Brontë sisters represent a fascinating and unique case in the history of English literature. The **extreme isolation** in which they lived was not an obstacle, but gave them the opportunity to develop a very personal voice and to deploy a level of freedom no other Victorian writer could use: this allowed them to challenge old literary conventions and to produce works that are still considered extremely modern by contemporary readers.



Social Reading Club

THE HIDDEN CANON

Leggi e commenta con gli studenti di tutta Italia!



↑ Anne, Emily and Charlotte Brontë painted by Branwell Brontë (ca. 1834), oil on canvas, National Portrait Gallery, London. He painted himself among his sisters, but later removed his image.

CHECKPOINT

2 Answer the following questions.

1. Why was reading considered an acceptable activity for Victorian women?
2. What topics were commonly addressed in Victorian novels to appeal to female readers?
3. Why did many Victorian female writers have to use male pseudonyms?
4. How did Victorian female writers contribute to developing women's rights and participation in society?
5. What is peculiar about Emily and Charlotte Brontë's novels?

ORACY Lab PRESENTATION

3 Use information contained in the paragraphs above to make a 2-minute presentation of the role of women in Victorian literary history.

WRITING Lab SHORT ESSAY

4 Focus on the picture you analysed in the Lead In activity. What aspects of Victorian society does it highlight? Are they still relevant today? Write your ideas in a short essay (max. 250 words). You may want to focus on:

- gender-related home activities;
- the right to 'free time' for men and women;
- the equal/unequal distribution of household tasks at home.

GETTING TO KNOW...

EMILY BRONTË

Wuthering Heights (1847)

VISUAL LESSON
EMILY BRONTË

VIDEO

10
REDUCED
INEQUALITIES

↑ Portrait of Emily Brontë painted by Branwell Brontë (1833), oil on canvas, National Portrait Gallery, London.

LEAD IN

1 Literature and cinema are full of stories about 'impossible love'.

1. Can you name at least two of them?
2. What do they have in common? How are they different?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

LISTENING

2 125 Complete Emily Brontë's biography with the following words. Then listen and check.

when | some | age | later | life | used | after | were

Who was Emily Brontë? (1818-1848)

The fourth of six children of an Anglican curate, Emily (Jane) Brontë was born on 30 July 1818 in Thornton, Yorkshire. She studied very briefly in a school with four of her sisters but when two of them died there one year **1**, she returned to the family home in Haworth, Yorkshire, where she would spend most of the rest of her **2** With her brother **Branwell** and two sisters, **Anne** and **Charlotte**, Emily delighted in inventing and telling stories. She later spent a year studying in Brussels with her two sisters, returning to Yorkshire **3** her aunt died. After an unsuccessful attempt at setting up a school with her sisters, the three of them spent their time at home, writing poems. In 1846 Charlotte included **4** of them in a collection called *Poems by Currer, Ellis, and Acton Bell*. These were pseudonyms **5** by the sisters to disguise their female identity, as the work of women writers was not easily published at the time. Only two copies **6** sold. However, two years later, Emily's only novel *Wuthering Heights* (1847) was published. The novel initially received a very mixed reception from readers. Soon **7** the publication she died of tuberculosis on 19 December 1848, at the **8** of 30.

Wuthering Heights - The plot

Wuthering Heights opens with the retrospective narration of Mr Lockwood, a visitor in Yorkshire reconstructing the story of **two households** on the Yorkshire moors: **Wuthering Heights**, where the Earnshaws live, and **Thrushcross Grange**, where the Lintons live. The story begins 30 years earlier, when Mr Earnshaw finds a homeless gypsy-boy named **Heathcliff** on a journey to Liverpool and adopts him as his son. Mr Earnshaw's son Hindley does not accept Heathcliff, but his sister **Catherine** grows attached to him. When Mr Earnshaw dies, Hindley declares Heathcliff will no longer be allowed an education and sends him to work in the fields. Heathcliff grows up ill-treated and gets terribly upset when Catherine, whom he loves, marries the wealthy **Edgar Linton** from Thrushcross Grange. Heathcliff runs away and returns a rich man to exact revenge on both families. Catherine's death does not free Heathcliff from the torments of his love-hate relationship with her and he is haunted by her **ghost** until the end of his life. After his death their two ghosts are said to walk together on the moor.



BEYOND THE BOOKSHELF

Emily's novel has been rewritten and **adapted several times** for both the **small and big screen**. Two of the most recent adaptations are the 2009 TV mini-series *Wuthering Heights*, starring Tom Hardy as Heathcliff, and the 2011 film, which, for the first time, features a black actor, James Howson, in the role of Heathcliff. In both versions, the **rugged Yorkshire countryside** plays an important role as a 'character' in the story.

The main themes

- **Love and passion:** the main theme of the novel is undoubtedly **the tormented, indecipherable, and impossible love** between Heathcliff and Catherine Earnshaw. Love is represented as a devastating feeling that creates a powerful bond between the two characters, transcending Victorian social conventions, and leading both of them to self-destruction and damnation.
- **Revenge:** Heathcliff's fierce revenge against Catherine's brother first and Edgar Linton later is one of the narrative engines of the novel, highlighting the **pagan, almost primitive forces** that dominate his character and adding a layer of gruesome passion to the novel. **The theme of revenge** – combined with the numerous morbid references to blood and death and the rejection of moral rules made by many of the characters – made the novel extremely shocking for the Victorian audience.
- **Nature vs civilisation:** the contrast between wild nature – with all its untamable and primordial forces – and civilisation – with its focus on respectability, rationality and rules – is **embodied by the contrast between the two mansions**. Wuthering Heights, as the name suggests, is a place of uncontrollable and primitive passions, while Thrushcross Grange is a place where order and civilisation reign.
- **The supernatural:** one of the striking features of the novel is the way the **landscape** and the main characters mirror each other. The landscape surrounding Wuthering Heights is dominated by moorland, a land that cannot be cultivated and is infertile: its apparent desolation makes the landscape a 'free land' where strange apparitions, supernatural events, and primordial forces interact and make themselves visible.

VIDEO
EMILY BRONTË

VIDEO

VOCABULARY Lab

3 Find the English translations of the following words (1-7) in the paragraph *The main themes*.

1. legame
2. vendetta
3. raccapricciante
4. morboso
5. indomabile
6. ville
7. incontrollabile

KEYTOPICS EQUALITY ISOLATION

Equality: the characters' struggle for equality. *Wuthering Heights* explores the characters' struggle for 'equality' through the **two main characters**. Heathcliff is an '**illegitimate**' child whom his brother treats as an 'outcast', making him feel 'isolated' and causing him a trauma that would fuel his anger and haunt him for the rest of his life. Catherine, on the other hand, is a **woman who is 'forced' not to marry Heathcliff**, the man she loves, because marrying him would prevent her from having a financially stable life, and condemns her to a life of loneliness. Through the tormented story of Heathcliff and Catherine, Emily Brontë explores **the clash between individual aspirations and material conditions**, one of the most fascinating conflicts of the novel, investigating the conditions which made 'equality' difficult in the Victorian Age.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

4 Answer the following questions.

1. What causes Heathcliff and Catherine's isolation? What effects does it have for both of them?
2. If Catherine were a contemporary woman, do you think her decisions as a woman would still be affected by 'inequality'?
3. If you were Catherine, would you follow her example and refuse Heathcliff? Why?/Why not?



↑ A scene from the film *Wuthering Heights* (1992) directed by Peter Kosminsky and starring Juliette Binoche as Catherine.

Narrative structure, language and style

The story of *Wuthering Heights* is told by **two narrators**, each with a distinctive point of view. One is Catherine's housekeeper, Nelly Dean, who, despite being an eye-witness to the events narrated, is not completely reliable because of her superstitions and prejudices. The other is the London visitor Mr Lockwood, who, terrified by a series of strange accidents that happened during his first night at Wuthering Heights, asks Nelly to tell him the story and writes it down in his diary. Mr Lockwood is an 'outsider' and does not fully understand the events narrated by Nelly. The combination of these two rather unreliable narrators contributes to creating an effect of **impersonality** that was quite unusual at the time, and enhances the story's mysterious and unconventional nature.

The plot does not follow the conventional sequence of events as it goes backwards and forwards through **flashbacks** and **personal recollections**. Quite interestingly, the novel starts at the end, when Mr Lockwood asks Nelly to tell him the story about Wuthering Heights.

Wuthering Heights incorporates some of the most typical elements of the **Gothic tradition** – including supernatural apparitions, ghosts, haunting presences, and gloomy atmospheres – and combines them with a profoundly **poetic and evocative narrative style**, characterised by frequent references to the wild natural landscape of Yorkshire (which reflects and enhances the torments and moral dilemmas of the novels' characters), recurring symbols, flashbacks, and the frequent use of idiomatic expressions.



← A scene from the film *Emily* (2022) directed by Frances O'Connor and starring Emma Mackey as Emily Brontë.

CHECKPOINT

5 Answer the following questions.

1. What events characterise Emily Brontë's life?
2. What are the main themes of *Wuthering Heights*?
3. What effect does the narrative structure of *Wuthering Heights* produce?
4. What type of woman is Catherine?
5. What is Heathcliff's personality like?

ORACY Lab PRESENTATION

6 Use the scheme above to make a 2-minute presentation of the complexity of the narrative structure of *Wuthering Heights*.



Wuthering Heights (1847)

The dilemma between heart and reason

LEAD IN

1 Look at this picture. Then answer the following questions.

1. What dilemma does it represent?
2. Which would you choose?
3. Is it always possible to make a free choice?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.



126

This is the first half of a long passage taken from Chapter 9. Catherine shares with Nelly her decision to marry Edgar Linton, who made a marriage proposal to her. Even if this seems to be a perfect decision according to societal expectations, there is something about this decision that agitates Catherine.

'Nelly, will you keep a secret for me?' she pursued, kneeling down by me, and lifting her winsome¹ eyes to my face with that sort of look which turns off bad temper, even when one has all the right in the world to indulge it.

'Is it worth keeping?' I inquired, less sulkily².

5 'Yes, and it worries me, and I must let it out! I want to know what I should do. Today, Edgar Linton has asked me to marry him, and I've given him an answer. Now, before I tell you whether it was a consent or denial, you tell me which it ought to have been.'

10 'Really, Miss Catherine, how can I know?' I replied. 'To be sure, considering the exhibition you performed in his presence this afternoon, I might say it would be wise to refuse him: since he asked you after that, he must either be hopelessly stupid or a venturesome fool³.'

'If you talk so, I won't tell you any more,' she returned, peevishly⁴ rising to her feet. 'I accepted him, Nelly. Be quick, and say whether I was wrong!'

15 'You accepted him! Then what good is it discussing the matter? You have pledged⁵ your word, and cannot retract.'

'But say whether I should have done so—do!' she exclaimed in an irritated tone; chafing⁶ her hands together, and frowning⁷.

'There are many things to be considered before that question can be answered properly,' I said, sententiously. 'First and foremost, do you love Mr Edgar?'

20 'Who can help it? Of course I do,' she answered.

Then I put her through the following catechism: for a girl of twenty-two it was not injudicious.

'Why do you love him, Miss Cathy?'

'Nonsense, I do—that's sufficient.'

25 'By no means; you must say why?'

'Well, because he is handsome, and pleasant to be with.'

'Bad!' was my commentary.

'And because he is young and cheerful.'

- 1 winsome: begli
- 2 sulkily: imbronciata
- 3 venturesome fool: folle che ama il rischio
- 4 peevishly: in maniera stizzita
- 5 pledged: dato
- 6 chafing: sfregandosi



↑ A scene from the film *Wuthering Heights* (2011) directed by Andrea Arnold and starring Kaya Scodelario as Catherine Earnshaw.

- 30 'Bad, still.'
'And because he loves me.'
'Indifferent, coming there.'
'And he will be rich, and I shall like to be the greatest woman of the neighbourhood, and I shall be proud of having such a husband.'
'Worst of all. And now, say how you love him?'
35 'As everybody loves—you're silly, Nelly.'
'Not at all—answer.'
'I love the ground under his feet, and the air over his head, and everything he touches, and every word he says. I love all his looks, and all his actions, and him entirely and altogether. There now!'
40 'And why?'
'Nay; you are making a jest of it⁸; it is exceedingly ill-natured⁹! It's no jest to me!' said the young lady, scowling¹⁰, and turning her face to the fire.
'I'm very far from jesting, Miss Catherine,' I replied. 'You love Mr Edgar because he is handsome, and young, and cheerful, and rich, and loves you. The last, however, goes for nothing: you would love him without that, probably; and with it you wouldn't, unless he possessed the four former attractions.'
45 'No, to be sure not: I should only pity him—hate him, perhaps, if he were ugly, and a clown.'
'But there are several other handsome, rich young men in the world: handsomer, possibly, and richer than he is. What should hinder¹¹ you from loving them?'
'If there be any, they are out of my way: I've seen none like Edgar.'
'You may see some; and he won't always be handsome, and young, and may not always be rich.'
'He is now; and I have only to do with the present. I wish you would speak rationally.'
55 'Well, that settles it: if you have only to do with the present, marry Mr Linton.'
'I don't want your permission for that—I shall marry him: and yet you have not told me whether I'm right.'
'Perfectly right; if people be right to marry only for the present. And now, let us hear what you are unhappy about. Your brother will be pleased; the old lady and gentleman will not object, I think; you will escape from a disorderly, comfortless home into a wealthy, respectable one; and you love Edgar, and Edgar loves you. All seems smooth and easy: where is the obstacle?'
60 'Here! and here!' replied Catherine, striking one hand on her forehead, and the other on her breast: 'in whichever place the soul lives. In my soul and in my heart, I'm convinced I'm wrong!'
65 'That's very strange! I cannot make it out.'
'It's my secret. But if you will not mock at me¹², I'll explain it: I can't do it distinctly; but I'll give you a feeling of how I feel.'

- 7 frowning: accigliata
8 you are making a jest of it: ti stai prendendo gioco della cosa
9 exceedingly ill-natured: estremamente indelicato
10 scowling: accigliandosi
11 hinder: impedire
12 if you will not mock at me: se non ti prenderai gioco di me

VOCABULARY Lab

- 2 Find these ten words in the text and arrange them as five pairs of opposites.

consent | handsome | hate | denial | love | right | silly | ugly | wise | wrong

COMPREHENSION

- 3 Complete the summary of the passage with the following words.

conflict | superficial | handsome | shares | proposal | loves | understand

In this passage, Catherine 1 _____ with Nelly, her housemaid, her final decision to accept Edgar Linton's 2 _____ to marry him. Nelly does not fully 3 _____. Catherine's decision and asks if she genuinely 4 _____. Edgar. Catherine says that she loves Edgar because he is 5 _____, pleasant, young, cheerful, wealthy, and in love with her. Nelly finds Catherine's motivations not entirely valid and somewhat 6 _____. Catherine insists that her decision is made, even if she admits feeling not fully convinced about it. By marrying Edgar, she would do what a woman in her condition would be expected to do according to societal expectations, but she also declares that her desires leave her in a state of internal 7 _____.

ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

- 4 Answer the following questions.

- The passage opens with Nelly's description of Catherine's attitude towards her.
 - What about Catherine's behaviour suggests that the secret she is about to share with Nelly is extremely important?
 - What does she want to know from Nelly?
- When Catherine tells Nelly she has accepted Edgar's proposal, Nelly asks her two important questions: one is 'do you love Mr Edgar?' (L 19). Which is the other one?
- Underline Catherine's replies to Nelly's second question. Why is Nelly unhappy with all of them? Do the qualities Catherine loves about Edgar make him really unique?
- In L 56 Catherine addresses Nelly quite aggressively by saying 'I don't want your permission for that'. What upsets her about Nelly's questions?
- What advantages does Nelly see in Catherine marrying Edgar?
- An 'obstacle' (L 62) prevents Catherine from being happy about her decision to marry Linton.
 - Where is this 'obstacle' according to Catherine?
 - How does the thought of it change Catherine's mood?
 - What is the cause of Catherine's agitation?



There is no 'I' in Wuthering Heights

In one of the essays contained in the collection *The Common Reader* (1925, 1932) Virginia Woolf (1882-1941) expresses her admiration for *Wuthering Heights*, and creates a portrait of Emily Brontë that highlights her uniqueness and colossal status in the panorama of world literature.



- There is no 'I' in *Wuthering Heights*. There are no governesses. There are no employers. There is love, but it is not the love of men and women. Emily was inspired by some more general conception. The impulse which urged her to create was not her own suffering or her own injuries. She looked out upon a world cleft¹ into gigantic disorder and felt within her the power to unite it in a book. That gigantic ambition is to be felt throughout the novel – a struggle, half thwarted² but of superb conviction, to say something through the mouths of her characters which is not merely 'I love' or 'I hate', but 'we, the whole human race' and 'you, the eternal powers...' the sentence remains unfinished. It is not strange that it should be so; rather it is astonishing that she can make us feel what she had it in her to say at all. It surges up in the half-articulate words of Catherine Earnshaw, 'If all else perished and HE remained, I should still continue to be; and if all else remained and he were annihilated, the universe would turn to a mighty stranger; I should not seem part of it'. It breaks out again in the presence of the dead. 'I see a repose that neither earth nor hell can break, and I feel an assurance of the endless and shadowless hereafter – the eternity they have entered – where life is boundless in its duration, and love in its sympathy and joy in its fullness.' It is this suggestion of power underlying the apparitions of human nature and lifting them up into the presence of greatness that gives the book its huge stature among other novels. ”

- 1 cleft: diviso
2 thwarted: contrastato

- 6 Answer the following questions.

- What characterises the theme of love in *Wuthering Heights* according to Woolf?
- What powerful metaphor does Woolf use to describe Emily's intention as a writer?
- Where does Emily's greatness lie according to Woolf? Explain it using your own words.
- Consider the context in which Emily lived. What 'limitations' characterised her life? Did they affect her writing?

Hell or Heaven?

LEAD IN

1 Answer the following questions.

- What ideas or emotions do you normally associate with Heaven?
- What images or symbols come to mind when you think of Hell?
- Have you ever experienced a situation that initially seemed like 'heaven' but later turned into 'hell'? If so, what happened?

Share your ideas with the rest of the class.

127

This is the second part of the dialogue between Catherine and Nelly: after sharing with Nelly her decision to marry Edgar, Catherine compares him with Heathcliff and tries to define the type of relationship that unites her and Heathcliff.

She seated herself by me again: her countenance grew sadder and graver, and her clasped hands trembled.

'Nelly, do you never dream queer¹ dreams?' she said, suddenly, after some minutes' reflection. 'Yes, now and then,' I answered.

- 5 'And so do I. I've dreamt in my life dreams that have stayed with me ever after, and changed my ideas: they've gone through and through me, like wine through water, and altered the colour of my mind. And this is one: I'm going to tell it—but take care not to smile at any part of it.'

10 'Oh! don't, Miss Catherine!' I cried. 'We're dismal² enough without conjuring up ghosts and visions to perplex us. Come, come, be merry and like yourself! Look at little Hareton³! He's dreaming nothing dreary. How sweetly he smiles in his sleep!'

'Yes; and how sweetly his father curses in his solitude! You remember him, I daresay, when he was just such another as that chubby thing⁴: nearly as young and innocent. However, Nelly, I shall oblige you to listen: it's not long; and I've no power to be merry tonight.'

15 'I won't hear it, I won't hear it!' I repeated, hastily⁵.

I was superstitious about dreams then, and am still; and Catherine had an unusual gloom⁶ in her aspect, that made me dread something from which I might shape a prophecy, and foresee a fearful catastrophe. She was vexed⁷, but she did not proceed. Apparently taking up another subject, she recommenced in a short time.

20 'If I were in heaven, Nelly, I should be extremely miserable.'

'Because you are not fit to go there,' I answered. 'All sinners would be miserable in heaven.'

'But it is not for that. I dreamt once that I was there.'

'I tell you I won't hearken⁸ to your dreams, Miss Catherine! I'll go to bed,' I interrupted again. She laughed, and held me down; for I made a motion to leave my chair.

25 'This is nothing,' cried she: 'I was only going to say that heaven did not seem to be my home; and I broke my heart with weeping to come back to earth; and the angels were so angry that they flung me out⁹ into the middle of the heath on the top of Wuthering Heights; where I woke sobbing for joy. That will do to explain my secret, as well as the other. I've no more business to marry Edgar Linton than I have to be in heaven; and if the wicked man¹⁰ in there had not brought Heathcliff so low, I shouldn't have thought of it. It would degrade me to marry Heathcliff now; so he shall never know how I love him; and that, not because he's handsome, Nelly, but because he's more myself than I am. Whatever our souls are made of, his and mine are the same; and Linton's is as different as a moonbeam from lightning, or frost from fire.'

- queer: strani
- dismal: triste
- Hareton: figlio di Hindley
- chubby thing: bambino paffuto
- hastily: precipitosamente
- gloom: tristezza
- vexed: irritata
- I won't hearken: non starò a sentire
- they flung me out: mi scaraventarono fuori
- wicked man: rifeito a Hindley



↑ Another scene from the film *Wuthering Heights* (1992) directed by Peter Kosminsky and starring Juliette Binoche as Catherine and Ralph Fiennes as Heathcliff.



VOCABULARY Lab

2 Find the English translation of these Italian words (1-8) in the extract.

- | | | |
|-------------|---------------|-----------|
| 1. sogni | 4. profezia | 7. angeli |
| 2. fantasmi | 5. catastrofe | 8. anime |
| 3. visioni | 6. cielo | |

COMPREHENSION

3 Complete the summary of the passage with the following words.

bond | sad | marry | dream | earth | her | never

Catherine shares with Nelly the account of a disturbing **1** she has recently had. In the dream, she feels **2** and miserable in heaven. Her desperation makes her desire to return to **3**, where she would be happier and more satisfied. She states that this dream corresponds to her decision to **4** Edgar: living with him would mean living in 'heaven' in terms of economic stability, but would probably be a 'hell' for **5**. She then admits that her true love is Heathcliff, who is connected with her through a **6** that no words can ever describe. Despite her love for him, Catherine declares that she could **7** marry Heathcliff.

ANALYSIS & INTERPRETATION

4 Answer the following questions.

- In order to describe the effect dreams had on her, Catherine uses a powerful metaphor. Find it and explain it in your own words.
- Focus on Catherine's dream.
 - Why does Catherine feel sad and miserable in heaven?
 - What does Nelly attribute Catherine's 'miserable state' to?
 - What do the angels decide to do?
- Why does Catherine believe she cannot marry Heathcliff?
- Catherine uses a hyperbole to describe what Heathcliff means to her.
 - Can you find it?
 - Can you explain what it means using your own words?
- What images does Catherine use to define the difference between Edgar and Heathcliff? What do they reveal about the character and the temperament of these two male characters?



#KEYTOPICS EQUALITY

Are men and women equal when it comes to marriage? In the passage it is evident that 'marriage' is regulated by **strict societal norms** that the characters seem to understand very well: the man is supposed to make the marriage proposal, while the woman has to decide whether to accept it or not. However, Catherine's reflections reveal that **men and women are not on the same level** when it comes to marriage: if men are free to choose their partner, women do not have the luxury to marry the partner they love when economic stability is not granted.

REFLECT & DISCUSS

5 Answer the following questions.

- Why is Catherine not free to choose the man she wants to marry? What considerations limit her freedom?
- In the Victorian Age people could benefit from a rising level of wellbeing and freedom due to economic growth. Does the passage you have just read reveal that this economic growth was for everyone, including women?
- Do you think that the imbalance between men and women highlighted in this passage no longer exists in the contemporary world?

WRITING Lab SHORT TEXT

6 Imagine you were Nelly: what advice would you give to Catherine? Should she stick to her decision to marry Edgar, even if she loves Heathcliff? Or should she choose to marry Heathcliff, knowing that her future would be poor and difficult? Write an argumentative text in which you explain your opinion (max. 150 words).

← *The Unequal Marriage* by Vasili Pukirev (1862), oil on canvas, State Tretyakov Gallery, Moscow. This painting depicts a sombre wedding scene, highlighting a stark social disparity. An elderly groom, dressed in formal attire with a medal on his chest, solemnly holds the hand of a much younger bride, who appears reluctant and melancholic. The picture conveys themes of inequality, societal pressure, and the constraints placed on individuals, particularly women, during the time.